

Phones in School

Building an evidence-based argument

Grade: 10 | **Content:** ELA / Civics + ENL

Proficiency: Transitioning-Expanding | **Duration:** 80 minutes

ENGLISH + SPANISH EDITION | Paired student materials on pages 5-7. Use these labels, prompts, and frames during the lesson sequence.

Portfolio focus: Source analysis, academic discussion, claims, evidence, reasoning, counterclaims, and rebuttals.

Lesson context

Students investigate how a school cellphone policy could balance learning and student needs. The aim is to evaluate evidence and construct a defensible argument; no particular position is required. Frame the debate as a hypothetical policy-design exercise where needed.

Essential question

How can we use evidence to construct a convincing argument?

Objectives

Content: Evaluate multiple perspectives on cellphone policies and construct an evidence-based claim.

Language: State a claim, attribute evidence to a source, explain reasoning, and respond to a counterclaim using academic connectors.

According to ____, ____.
This supports my claim because ____.
Some people argue _____. However, _____.

Vocabulary

claim, evidence, reasoning, credible, source, argument, counterclaim, rebuttal, distraction, policy. Define a claim as an arguable position, evidence as information supporting it, and reasoning as the explanation of that connection.

Materials and preparation

Prepare three short, properly cited sources, a source-analysis organizer, discussion-role cards, a writing frame, a rubric, and an exit ticket. Provide accessible texts and vocabulary glossaries.

Source packet required: The earlier lesson specifies source types rather than actual readings. This PDF preserves that design and does not present invented research as evidence. Select and verify the readings before classroom use.

Read beyond the headline

Source A: Research or research summary

Select an accessible study or accurately attributed summary about phone access, notifications, attention, or learning. Include author/organization, title, date, link, and relevant passage. Identify who was studied and what the findings can and cannot establish.

Source B: Student perspective

Choose an attributed student perspective on communication, safety, organization, or educational use. Distinguish lived experience and opinion from research evidence. Do not assume one student represents all students.

Source C: Policy example

Select a real, dated policy and explain its context. Have students distinguish what a policy **requires** from evidence about whether it **works**. A policy allowing access at certain times may be used as a comparison if appropriate to its jurisdiction.

Teacher preparation checks

Confirm that every excerpt accurately represents its source. Provide links or citations on the student packet and use excerpts within applicable permissions. Pair a language-supported summary with the original where needed.

Check the local policy context before teaching. Distinguish an imagined policy recommendation from what a school is currently permitted or required to implement.

Source-analysis organizer

For **each source A, B, and C**, students record:

1. Author/organization, title, date, and source type.
2. Main claim or policy position.
3. Relevant evidence or example.
4. Perspective and purpose.
5. Credibility: Why trust it, and what are its limits?
6. How it supports or challenges the student's developing claim.

Teacher modeling

Model one verified passage from the prepared packet. Separate the author's claim, the information offered as support, and the student's reasoning. Ask whether the source directly supports the conclusion or only suggests a possibility.

Claim: Schools should ____.

Evidence: According to [prepared source], [accurate finding or example].

Reasoning: This supports the claim because ____.

Limitation: This source does not establish ____.

Analyze. Discuss. Argue.

1. Opinion continuum | 6 minutes

Display: “Cellphones should be prohibited during the entire school day.” Students choose strongly agree, agree, unsure, disagree, or strongly disagree. Offer seated or private responses. Invite brief reasons and explain that positions may change after reading.

2. Vocabulary and modeling | 10 minutes

Teach claim, evidence, reasoning, credibility, counterclaim, and rebuttal using a short passage from the prepared packet. Model attribution and explain how evidence connects to a claim.

3. Source analysis | 18 minutes

Read the three short sources individually or with partners and complete the organizer. Students distinguish research, perspective, and policy, then identify a useful piece of evidence and a limitation.

4. Academic discussion | 14 minutes

In groups of four, assign facilitator, evidence finder, questioner, and summarizer. Discuss: **What cellphone policy would best balance learning and student needs?** Each student contributes a source-based point and responds to a peer.

I agree with ____ because ____.

Another piece of evidence is ____.

I understand that perspective, but the evidence suggests ____.

Can you explain why ____ supports your argument?

5. Argument writing | 25 minutes

Draft a short argument with a claim, relevant attributed evidence, reasoning, counterclaim, and rebuttal. Suggested organization: paragraph 1, claim and context; paragraph 2, evidence and reasoning; paragraph 3, counterclaim and response.

Treat this as an initial draft. Adjust length and provide a later revision period when needed. Assess reasoning and use of sources rather than agreement with the teacher.

6. Exit ticket | 7 minutes

Ask: **Did your opinion change after examining the sources? Explain why or why not using one piece of evidence.** Students may keep their original position if their reasoning is supported.

Support rigorous argument

Language supports

Transitioning: Chunked texts, vocabulary glosses, partner reading, selectively highlighted evidence, an organizer, and optional sentence starters.

Expanding: Original passages with targeted vocabulary support; require a counterclaim and a clear response.

Commanding extension: Compare evidence strength, identify limitations or bias, and qualify conclusions. Extend the reasoning rather than simply adding length.

Schools should ____ because ____.
 According to ____, ____.
 This evidence supports ____ because ____.
 Some people argue _____. However, _____.
 Therefore, _____.

Assessment criteria

Claim: Clear, defensible, and responsive to the prompt.

Evidence: Relevant information accurately attributed to prepared sources.

Reasoning: Explains how evidence supports the claim.

Counterclaim: Represents another view fairly and provides a reasoned response.

Language: Communicates relationships using academic vocabulary and transitions.

Scoring guide

Score each criterion from 1 to 4 (20 points total):

4 - Strong: Clear, accurate, developed, and consistently fulfills the criterion.

3 - Adequate: Fulfills the criterion with a minor gap or limited elaboration.

2 - Partial: Present but unclear, weakly supported, or incomplete.

1 - Beginning: Missing or does not yet show the criterion.

These are task-performance ratings, not ENL proficiency labels. Record scaffold use separately; language errors should not erase evidence of strong reasoning.

Formative checks and access

Review organizers before discussion. If a student lists evidence without reasoning, ask “Why does this matter for your claim?” Offer oral rehearsal, home-language notes, bilingual resources, accessible digital text, and speech-to-text as appropriate. Follow individual IEP/504 supports.

Portfolio rationale and reflection

The sequence moves from opinion to evidence, discussion, and argument. Explicit language supports allow students to engage in rigorous analysis while developing academic English.

After teaching, compare initial positions, organizer notes, and final arguments. Ask whether students attributed evidence, recognized source limits, and answered a counterclaim. This is a design rationale, not a report of observed outcomes.

Language for argument

Lenguaje para argumentar

Teacher use: Display paired labels beside the same image in equally readable type. Read and model both labels when possible. Invite Spanish or bilingual planning, then support English practice toward the language objective. Offer other language supports as needed; Spanish is not every learner's home language.

ENGLISH	ESPAÑOL
claim: the position you defend	postura: la idea que defiendes
evidence: information supporting a claim	evidencia: información que respalda una postura
reasoning: how evidence supports a claim	razonamiento: cómo la evidencia respalda una postura
source / credible source	fuentes / fuentes confiables
counterclaim: an opposing position	contraargumento: una postura opuesta
rebuttal: a reasoned response	refutación: una respuesta razonada
policy / distraction / notification	norma / distracción / notificación
Image labels: cellphone / classroom	Etiquetas: teléfono celular / aula
learning / communication / safety	aprendizaje / comunicación / seguridad

Prompt and goal / Pregunta y meta

ENGLISH	ESPAÑOL
What cellphone policy would best balance learning and student needs?	¿Qué norma sobre el uso de celulares equilibraría mejor el aprendizaje y las necesidades de los estudiantes?
I can state a claim, cite evidence, explain my reasoning, and respond to another viewpoint.	Puedo presentar una postura, citar evidencia, explicar mi razonamiento y responder a otro punto de vista.

Read, evaluate, and discuss

Lee, evalúa y conversa

Teacher preparation: Pair these prompts with the verified source packet described on page 2. Supply clearly labeled Spanish translations or summaries of selected passages alongside the original English. Preserve source credits; the source readings and their translations are not included here.

ENGLISH	ESPAÑOL
Read each source. Take notes in English, Spanish, or both.	Lee cada fuente. Toma notas en inglés, español o ambos idiomas.
Who created it? When? What type of source is it?	¿Quién la creó? ¿Cuándo? ¿Qué tipo de fuente es?
What is its main claim? What evidence does it provide?	¿Cuál es su postura principal? ¿Qué evidencia presenta?
Why is it credible? What are its limitations?	¿Por qué es confiable? ¿Cuáles son sus limitaciones?
Does it support or challenge your claim? How?	¿Respalda o cuestiona tu postura? ¿Cómo?

Group roles / Funciones en el grupo

ENGLISH	ESPAÑOL
Facilitator / Evidence finder	Moderador/a / Encargado/a de buscar evidencia
Questioner / Summarizer	Encargado/a de hacer preguntas / Encargado/a de resumir

Discussion stems / Modelos para conversar

ENGLISH	ESPAÑOL
I agree with ____ because ____.	Estoy de acuerdo con ____ porque ____.
Another piece of evidence is ____.	Otra evidencia es ____.
I understand that perspective, but the evidence suggests ____.	Entiendo ese punto de vista, pero la evidencia indica que ____.
Can you explain why ____ supports your argument?	¿Puedes explicar por qué ____ respalda tu argumento?

Build your argument

Construye tu argumento

ENGLISH	ESPAÑOL
Plan in either language or both. Write an English draft with support. Use a claim, evidence, reasoning, a counterclaim, and a rebuttal.	Planea en cualquiera de los dos idiomas o en ambos. Escribe un borrador en inglés con apoyo. Incluye una postura, evidencia, razonamiento, un contraargumento y una refutación.
Claim: Schools should ____ because ____.	Postura: Las escuelas deberían ____ porque ____.
Evidence: According to ____, ____.	Evidencia: Según ____, ____.
Reasoning: This supports my claim because ____.	Razonamiento: Esto respalda mi postura porque ____.
Counterclaim: Some people argue that ____.	Contraargumento: Algunas personas sostienen que ____.
Rebuttal: However, ____ because ____.	Refutación: Sin embargo, ____ porque ____.

Self-check / Autoevaluación

ENGLISH	ESPAÑOL
Is my position clear? Did I name the source and represent its evidence accurately?	¿Está clara mi postura? ¿Nombré la fuente y presenté su evidencia con precisión?
Did I explain my reasoning and respond fairly to another view?	¿Explicué mi razonamiento y respondí de manera justa a otro punto de vista?

Exit ticket / Boleto de salida

ENGLISH	ESPAÑOL
Did your opinion change after reading the sources? Explain why or why not using one piece of evidence.	¿Cambió tu opinión después de leer las fuentes? Explica por qué cambió o por qué no cambió usando una evidencia.